1.5 How computers help

In this lesson

You will learn:

- about the benefits of using a computer.

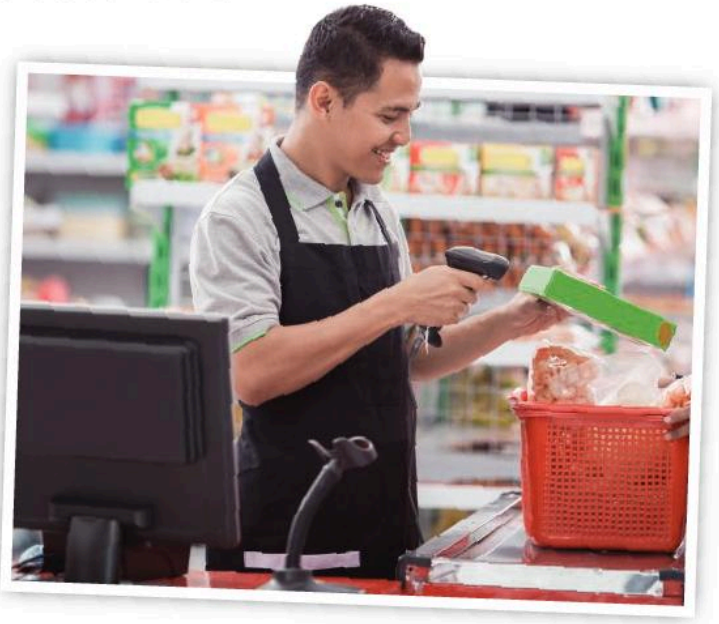


Benefits

'Benefit' means to make things better. People use computers because they bring benefits. Computers can help you to do things better.

Here are some benefits of using computers:

- **Make work easier.** The computer can make it easier to do some tasks.
- **Fast and accurate.** The computer does accurate sums and measurements.
- **Store facts and find things out.** The computer can store facts and find answers, including using the internet.
- **Long-distance communication.** The computer can send messages to people all over the world.
- **Clear and neat work.** The computer makes output that is neat and clear.
- **Work without rest.** The computer can control machines and devices day and night without rest.



In the last lesson you learned about some ways the computer helped a doctor and a shopkeeper.

The table on the next page shows these benefits for a doctor and a shopkeeper. There are some gaps.

Benefits	Doctor's work	Shopkeeper's work
Make work easier	Make appointments for patients.	Take payments from customers. Pay wages to staff.
Fast and accurate		
Store facts and find things out		Find out about new products. Store facts about the items for sale.
Long-distance communication	Send messages to doctors in other hospitals.	
Clear and neat work	Print out charts and diagrams to help spot illness.	
Work without rest		Store food at an even temperature at all times.



Activity

Make a copy of the table. Look back at the last lesson. Look at all the tasks a doctor and a shopkeeper do. Put each task into the right box of the table. Some have already been done for you.





Extra challenge

You have looked at the job of a doctor and a shopkeeper. Now think of the job of a teacher. Think of all the ways a teacher might use a computer.

- Write down all the benefits you can think of.
- Can you link them to the benefits on this page?
- Make a final column for the table to show the benefits to a teacher.



Be creative

Choose one of the jobs shown on this page (doctor, shopkeeper or teacher). Instead of words, draw cartoons to show how they would use computers.

Think again

Give examples from your school work where the computer has helped you:

- to find out facts
- to do clear and neat work.

1.6 Making good choices

In this lesson

You will learn:

- how to choose tasks where a computer can or cannot help
- how to choose the right computer for a task.



Limitations

Computers have limitations. That means things the computer is not so good at.

Here are some things that computers cannot do.

- **Do something creative.** The computer cannot invent new things or be creative.
- **Understand people.** The computer cannot understand how people feel. The computer cannot show human feelings or make friendships.
- **Take responsibility.** Computers can give people information to help them make decisions. But you must make your own choices.

Limitations	Doctor's work	Shopkeeper's work
Doing something creative		
Understanding people		
Taking responsibility		

Here are some examples of tasks that a doctor or a shopkeeper might do.

Decide between two treatments.

Listen to a patient talk about their worries.

Talk to a customer about what they want to buy.

Create an advert for the shop.

Decide to change the prices in the shop.

Invent a new way to cure a disease.



Activity

Make a copy of the table on the previous page. Put the activities into the table to show things a doctor or shopkeeper can do that a computer cannot do.

Choose the right device

If you use a computer for a task you need to choose the right device. Here are the devices you have learned about in this unit.

Desktop computer	
Laptop computer	
Tablet	
Smartphone	



Activity

Here are some things people said. Recommend the ideal digital device for each person.

- "I want to do a lot of typing sitting at my desk."
- "I want to play a computer game on the bus to school."



Extra challenge

Pick a digital device you did not choose. Say one thing a person might do with that device.

Think again

Say one thing a teacher can do that a computer cannot do.



Digital citizen of the future

At school you often have to use a computer because your teacher says so! But when you are grown up you will be able to make decisions.

- Do you want to use a computer?
- What device do you choose?

Learning about computers at school will help you make good decisions in the future.